

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Endowed with the Limbs of All the Buddhas"

Ārya-sarvabuddhāṅgavatī-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 856 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་མཆོག་གི་ལྷན་པ་ཞེས་བརྒྱུད་པའི་ཐུགས་རྒྱུ་གླེང་པའི་ཐུགས་རྒྱུ་

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Endowed with the Limbs of All the Buddhas" (Sanskrit Ārya-sarvabuddhāṅgavatī-nāma-dhāraṇī, Tibetan Phags pa sangs rgyas thams cad kyi yan lag dang ldan pa zhes bya ba'i gzungs) is a short scripture centered on a protective incantation. It is set on the bank of the Ganges, where the Buddha addresses the four great kings, the Guardians of the World, headed by Vaiśravaṇa. He speaks to them of the four great fears that afflict human beings, namely aging, sickness, decline, and death, and singles out the fear of the lord of death as the greatest, since it has no traceable beginning, admits no antidote, and always follows close behind. The text then offers its dhāraṇī as a means of protection against these dangers. It is Toh 856 in the Kangyur, where it is classed among the dhāraṇīs of the Tantra division.

In the language of India: Ārya-sarvabuddhāṅgavatī-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Endowed with the Limbs of All the Buddhas."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling on the bank of the great river Gaṅgā together with the four Guardians of the World. At that time the Blessed One spoke to the four great kings, headed by Vaiśravaṇa, saying:

Great kings, these four great fears arise for men, women, boys, and girls. What are the four? They are aging, sickness, decline, and death. Among these there is one that is the greatest fear, namely the great fear of the lord of death: it has no beginning that can be traced, it has no antidote, and it follows always close behind. Great kings, I shall now speak here the antidote to that one great fear.

Then the four great kings said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, because the Blessed One has granted us the gift of life, and has taken up this multitude of beings, today we have gained a good gain.

Then the Blessed One sat facing the east, and with the sound of a conch he summoned all the Tathāgatas, saying: Tathāgatas, foe-destroyers, perfectly awakened buddhas, all of you who, out of compassion for sentient beings,

became fully and perfectly awakened into unsurpassed, perfect awakening, be my companions. Therefore, blessed here by the blessing of all the buddhas, I shall turn back the untimely death of all sentient beings. I shall also turn a second wheel of Dharma, one not turned before.

In the same way he summoned all the Tathāgatas of the south, the west, the north, above, and below, saying: Tathāgatas, foe-destroyers, perfectly awakened buddhas, all of you who, for the sake of compassion for sentient beings, became fully and perfectly awakened into unsurpassed, perfect awakening, be my companions.

In the same way, in the intermediate directions also, he spoke thus: So that these beings may be perfectly endowed with life, strength, and good complexion, and so that the fear of untimely death may not arise, may all the buddhas be my companions.

Then, as far as the realms of the earth in the ten directions come within the vision of the buddhas, so many world systems were filled by the Buddha, the Blessed One, as a sesame seed pod is filled with seeds. Those Tathāgatas, having consented to be his companions, all spoke thus:

Tadyathā: cala cala cale, binhi, svastike, cakra, aṅgati, praśamantu, sarvaroga, anaṭe, kunaṭe, mahākunaṭe, care care re, hemagiri, hemagauri, hemaniśunti, hemasisi, kaurbe kaurbave, he kurare, kurare, kumati, viśasamaṇe, śiṣubhi, cale cale, vicala, mā vilamba, humu humu svāhā.

All the lords of secrets (the yakṣa chiefs) who were present sat close to all the Tathāgatas, and they said: Hūṃ hūṃ, sisi svāhā.

When this had been spoken, all the Tathāgatas became invisible.

Then the great king Vaiśravaṇa said to the Blessed One:

Blessed One, I too will protect with the blessing of the Tathāgatas. I will turn back untimely death. Tadyathā: śvete, śvete, śveta, lelili.

Then the one called Ārya-born (Ārya-jāta) also spoke: Mātaṅge, mātaṅge, mātaṅgini, śūmā, śūmu.

Then Dhṛtarāṣṭra, protector of the realm, also spoke: Care, care, re svāhā.

Then Virūpākṣa (he of the unsightly eyes) also spoke: Balimbapa.

The Blessed One then declared: Great kings, if anyone recites this vidyā-mantra, which is looked upon by all the buddhas, once each day, then toward that son or daughter of good family one should give rise to the

perception of the Teacher. That son or daughter of good family will not go to the three lower realms. By this one will benefit the life of all sentient beings. One who recites it word by word, day after day, for the sake of all sentient beings, and anyone who reads it, will have no fear of untimely death. No evil disease will arise in that person's body. That person will not meet death by water, nor by fire, nor by weapons, nor by poison, nor by a fall from a precipice.

Wherever the sons of the Victor recite this vidyā-mantra, that place should be known as held in the mind of all the buddhas and bodhisattvas. One who writes it down, or who causes it to be written down, will have honored the Buddha, the Blessed One, with every kind of reverent service. Why is that? Because the Tathāgatas have said that to serve sentient beings is to serve the buddhas. Whoever writes this out and wears it on the limbs of the body will have all the limbs of that body protected.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the four great kings, together with that entire retinue, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

Here ends the dhāraṇī called The Noble One Endowed with the Limbs of All the Buddhas.

It was translated, revised, and finalized by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the great editor-translator, the venerable Yeshe De, and was further corrected in accordance with the new terminology.

Translator's Notes

- The mantra is transliterated as it stands in the Tibetan; its Sanskrit is corrupt in places (for example binhi, aṅgati, kaurbe, śiṣubhi), so the forms given are provisional and not emended. The phrase "it has no beginning that can be traced" renders a term whose sense is uncertain, and it may rather mean "without any undertaking," that is, nothing can be done to forestall it. The statement that the Buddha "has taken up this multitude of beings" and the kings' gratitude after "granting life" is a condensed exchange, and the connection between the kings' remark and the Buddha's gift of life is somewhat elliptical in the Tibetan. "Lords of secrets" translates a term that here refers to Vajrapāṇi-type yakṣa chiefs; I have glossed it accordingly. The passage breaks off mid-narrative, at the opening of Vaiśravaṇa's speech.
- The Tibetan names the four great kings only obliquely. "Ārya-born" (འཕྲེལ་བའི་རྒྱལ་པོ་, Virūḍhaka, king of the south) and "Protector of the Realm" (འཕྲེལ་བའི་རྒྱལ་པོ་, Dhṛtarāṣṭra, king of the east) are the standard epithets, and "Unsightly Eyes" (འཕྲེལ་བའི་རྒྱལ་པོ་, Virūpākṣa, king of the west) is also standard. I have identified them in the translation by their epithets plus Sanskrit equivalents, following the usual correspondences. The "Ārya-born" identification as Virūḍhaka is the least certain. The mantra syllables are transliterated from the Tibetan rendering of Sanskrit and are likely corrupt in places, so I have not tried to normalize them. The

phrase "to give rise to the perception of the Teacher" (師を起す) means regarding that person as one would regard the Buddha. The phrase "wears it on the limbs" literally reads "binds it on the limbs," as an amulet.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.